The Voting Rights Act of 1965

U.S. Congress · signed by President Lyndon B. Johnson, August 6, 1965

Source: Voting Rights Act of 1965 (Aug. 6, 1965), text via the U.S. National Archives, Milestone Documents. Public domain.

Passed weeks after the violent suppression of the Selma-to-Montgomery marches, the Voting Rights Act enforced the Fifteenth Amendment by banning literacy tests and authorizing federal oversight of voter registration in areas with a history of discrimination. Black voter registration in the South rose dramatically, making the act one of the most consequential achievements of the civil rights movement.

Connect: How did the events at Selma create the political pressure that made this law possible in 1965?

Key Passages

Section 2 — the core protection

> No voting qualification or prerequisite to voting, or standard, practice, or procedure shall be imposed or applied by any State or political subdivision to deny or abridge the right of any citizen of the United States to vote on account of race or color.

Suspending the tests

> To assure that the right of citizens of the United States to vote is not denied or abridged on account of race or color, no citizen shall be denied the right to vote in any Federal, State, or local election because of his failure to comply with any test or device in any State with respect to which the determinations have been made under subsection (b)

Federal examiners

> Any person whom the examiner finds, in accordance with instructions received under section 9(b), to have the qualifications prescribed by State law not inconsistent with the Constitution and laws of the United States shall promptly be placed on a list of eligible voters.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The civil rights movement; violent attacks on voting-rights marchers at Selma ('Bloody Sunday,' 1965) shocked the nation after years of disenfranchisement.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Southern states and election officials, federal officials who would enforce it, and Black voters who would gain access to the ballot.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Congress and President Lyndon Johnson, responding to movement pressure; it reflects the federal government's newly active role in protecting civil rights.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Explain ONE effect of the Voting Rights Act on American democracy.
2. Why was active federal enforcement — not simply a ban — necessary to protect voting rights in 1965?
3. How did the Voting Rights Act build on the promise of the Fifteenth Amendment (1870)?